

One Cup, Two Loyalties

Can an environmental argument protect both a principle and a family relationship?



The poster on the pantry door

At 6:35 on Friday morning, Leila Rahman taped a poster to the pantry door of her family's cafe. In thick green letters it asked, "How many throwaway cups does one busy morning need?" Underneath, she proposed a four-week trial: reward customers who brought a clean reusable cup, offer ceramic mugs to people drinking inside and test a small returnable-mug shelf.

Leila had spent the holidays helping at the register. She saw towers of cups arrive and watched bins fill before lunch. To her, the cups represented a choice repeated so often that it became invisible. She wanted her family to lead change.

Her first slogan sounded powerful: "Our cafe is choosing convenience over the planet." Then she imagined her aunt beside the coffee machine. The sentence made the adults sound careless. Leila knew that was not true.

What the slogan leaves out

Aunt Samira opened most mornings, checked deliveries, trained staff and made sure wages could be paid. She liked Leila's goal, but not being treated as an obstacle.

"A good idea still has to work at 7:45, when twenty people are waiting and a customer hands us a cup that may not be clean."

Her concern was not a secret wish to keep wasting cups. She wanted answers: Who would inspect a cup? Where would staff place it? What if it was dirty, damaged or the wrong size? Would a return shelf add washing during the rush? What would the cafe offer someone who forgot a cup?

Leila felt the argument changing. Repeating that waste mattered would not answer the people affected. She needed to represent their concern fairly and propose a test that could produce local evidence.

MARK THE FEATURE

- V** value or responsibility
- C** genuine concern
- E** checkable evidence
- T** technique or framing

Family decision

Should Sunrise Corner test a reusable-cup system for four weeks?

FICTION BOUNDARY

The cafe, family and dialogue are invented. Official sources support the evidence section.

WORD HELP

livelihood: work and income that support a person or family

concession: fair acknowledgement of a point made by another side

straw man: an unfairly simplified version of another view

modality: the force or certainty carried by words such as could, should and must

Build a bridge, not a battle

Evidence that changes the conversation

Queensland Government guidance suggests offering an incentive to customers who bring a reusable cup or drink in store. It also suggests a mug-return program, possibly with a deposit. These are options, not guarantees; one system will not suit every queue or workspace.

Food Standards Australia New Zealand explains that a business may decide whether to accept customer reusable cups. It should use a policy and consider cleaning, sanitising and cross-contamination. The business remains responsible for safe and suitable food.

Evidence boundary: Official guidance supports avoidance, reuse and a clear safety policy. It does not prove that a four-week trial will remove all waste or cause no delay. A trial can collect local evidence.

Two drafts for the family meeting

Draft A - Heat

Our throwaway habit is choking the planet because the cafe refuses to change. How can money matter more than our future? We must ban disposable cups now.

Draft B - FAIR bridge

We all want Sunrise Corner to remain welcoming and responsible. A morning rush makes safety and speed genuine concerns. Official guidance shows that a cafe can set a clear cup policy, so we should test a four-week system and measure what happens.

The FAIR bridge

F

Frame a shared goal

A

Acknowledge a fair concern

I

Introduce relevant evidence

R

Recommend a workable next step

Technique field guide

Inclusive language Frames shared responsibility: we, our, together.

Modality Calibrates force: could, should, must.

Rhetorical question Directs attention - or unfairly pressures an audience.

Emotive words Signal importance, but may attack instead of explain.

Concession Shows the writer understands a genuine concern.

Call to action Names a specific, safe and workable next step.

Open-letter challenge

Write 9-11 sentences to the Rahman family. Be firm about the ethical goal, fair about the family's responsibilities and specific about what the trial will test.

Source trail: Queensland Government business guide and Action on single-use plastic items; Food Standards Australia New Zealand customer cups and food packaging guidance; Brisbane City Council bin guidance as a local disposal example.